

newspaper headline, and we clam up. Sometimes we fear being berated, but sometimes we just don't want to be patronized. We certainly don't want to put ourselves in a position where our financial failings can be weaponized against us, so we don't say anything at all – even when it is bubbling violently just below the surface, robbing us of precious hours of sleep, limiting our choices and stunting our personal growth.

There are a few reasons why this is, I think, and each of them is quite complex and nuanced. It's not only down to personal fears and insecurities, but there are also broader societal issues that keep our lips sealed.

We're measuring ourselves by the wrong yardstick

Much of the narrative around money in society and the media is built around one single blueprint for how our financial lives should look – but it is a blueprint that is both out of date and out of touch with the reality in which most of us are now living. And yet we continue to measure our successes, and those of our peers, against an antiquated yardstick of early property ownership, jobs for life and affordable living costs. Not to mention the wedding and children we simply *must* have to make our lives complete. If we are female, we often feel as though we must also do this while looking a certain way – and all of that personal grooming and fast fashion comes at a financial cost too. This gold standard of money management – although unachievable for so